

The clausal demonstrative in Czech^{*}

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Abstract This study is concerned with the so-called clausal demonstrative in Czech – the morphologically invariable demonstrative *to*, which is morphologically related to the ordinary nominal demonstrative, but differs from it in that it attaches to finite clauses. Based on an informal corpus study, I distinguish three different uses of the clausal demonstrative – the topic-related use, the focus-related use (akin to clefts), and thethetic use. The theoretical proposal has a syntactic and a semantic part. In syntax, the clausal demonstrative lexically encodes an array of left-peripheral heads (Top-Foc-Fin), each of which corresponds to one use type. The semantic proposal relies on the idea that the clausal demonstrative inherits the core property of the nominal demonstrative: it establishes a relation (typically identity) between the (propositional) denotation of the demonstrative’s complement and a contextually salient (propositional) referent.

Keywords: clausal demonstrative; discourse anaphora; focus; (contrastive) topic; thetic constructions; clefts; clausal/nominal parallelism

1 Introduction

The Czech demonstrative *to* can attach to both nominals and clauses. In its canonical (adnominal or pronominal) use it inflects for case, number, and gender, see (1a), (1b); in its clausal use it is insensitive to these categories and its form is default, corresponding to the nominative/accusative, singular, neuter form of the adnominal demonstrative, see (1c). I will gloss the clausal demonstrative as CDEM throughout the paper.

- (1) a. *to* *máslo*
 DEM.NOM/ACC.SG.N butter.NOM/ACC.SG.N
 ‘the/this/that butter’
- b. *těm* *sousedům*
 DEM.DAT.PL.M neighbors.DEM.DAT.PL.M
 ‘(to) the/these/those neighbors’
- c. *To* *sousedům* *volala.*
 CDEM neighbors.DAT.PL.M called.SG.F
 (i) ‘It was the neighbors that she called.’
 (ii) ‘As for the neighbors, she called them.’

In this paper, I explore the properties and types of the clausal demonstrative. I argue for the existence of three types – thethetic demonstrative (illustrated below), the focus-related demonstrative ((1c-i)), and the topic-related demonstrative ((1c-ii)). I argue that

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the types correspond to an incrementally growing syntactic structure parasitic on the cartographic left periphery (from Fin(-Dem) to Top-Foc-Fin(-Dem)). I further argue that the semantics of the clausal demonstrative correlates with the semantics of nominal demonstrative: it takes its complement (propositional in the clausal case) and relates it to a contextually salient (propositional) referent.

The paper is organized as follows. Section 2 defines the clausal demonstrative and distinguishes its basic uses. This section builds on an informal corpus study and, thereby, on authentic corpus data and some basic descriptive statistics. Section 3 presents the analytical proposal – both (morpho)syntactic, couched in the nanosyntactic framework, and semantic, couched in the formal-semantic framework. Section 3.3 discusses a number of predictions of the proposal. Section 4 compares the proposal to existing ones, concerning mainly the Russian and Polish correlate of the Czech clausal demonstrative. Section 5 summarizes the findings and mentions some significant open issues.

2 Clausal demonstrative: definition and different uses

2.1 Definition

For purposes of this paper, I define the clausal demonstrative (i) as a morphologically invariant demonstrative (taking the form of a nominative/accusative singular neuter default/non-reinforced demonstrative), which (ii) has a fixed position in the clausal left periphery. I argue that the properties (i) and (ii) have a common denominator: the clausal demonstrative spells out a series of left-peripheral functional heads and as such it is not in a configuration (i) where it would be subject to case-marking, agreement, or concord, and (ii) where it could be targeted by (phrasal) movement operations. The examples in (2) all involve a clausal demonstrative in this sense. The different subtypes, labeled in the subexample headings, will be discussed in more detail in section 2.2.¹

- (2) a. Topic-related CDEM
Context: ‘There are only lower thousands of refugees heading to Roraima.’
 To do Kolumbie [...] míří desetitisíce. [C]
 CDEM to Columbia head ten.thousands
 ‘By contrast, tens of thousands [of refugees] are heading to Columbia.’
- b. Focus-related CDEM
Context: ‘Bertil wasn’t involved in the crime at all.’
 To Eva vyfoukla peníze. [C]
 CDEM Eva stole money
 ‘It was Eva who stole the money.’
- c. Thetic CDEM
Context: ‘It’s so nice to file a completed document.’

¹ Much of the data reported in this article stem from informal corpus searches in the Czech National Corpus (Křen et al. 2023). From a random sample of 500 occurrences of clause-initial *to* followed by a non-neuter noun or a preposition, 144 fit the adopted definition of a clausal demonstrative (59 topic-related, 58 focus-related, 19thetic, the rest hard to categorize). Corpus data are marked [C]. Modified corpus examples accompanied by my personal native speaker intuition are marked with [M]. The contexts provided are simplified and capture the gist of the actual context in the corpus. Unless indicated otherwise, unmarked examples are in Czech and are constructed by myself (a native speaker of Czech). Modified and constructed examples are not to be understood as empirical facts, but as hypotheses about the empirical situation.

To člověk hned cítí příjemný pocit vykonané povinnosti. [C]
 CDEM human immediately feels pleasant sense accomplished task.GEN
 '[In that case] One immediately gets a pleasant sense of accomplishment.'

I use modified versions of example (2b) to illustrate the definitional properties of clausal demonstratives. Example (3a) shows that the clausal demonstrative cannot agree in phi-features with the constituent it semantically associates with, the focused subject *Eva* in this case. I note that the example is grammatical and fully acceptable if the agreeing demonstrative is understood as a recognitional or affective demonstrative (see Šimík 2016). Example (3b) illustrates that the clausal *to* cannot be used in a non-peripheral position, whether the specific placement of *to* in (3b) is understood as adjunction to the associated focus (*Eva*) or to some lower projection of the (extended) verb phrase. I note that the OVS order used in (3b) is grammatical and very common for focused subjects (Jasinskaja & Šimík forthcoming); this is illustrated in (3c), which also shows that *to* differs from (other) focus-sensitive particles.

- (3) a. **Ta* Eva vyfoukla peníze. [M]
 DEM.NOM.SG.F Eva.NOM.SG.F stole money
 Intended: 'It was Eva who stole the money.'
- b. *Peníze vyfoukla *to* Eva. [M]
 money stole CDEM Eva
 (Intended:) 'It was Eva who stole the money.'
- c. Peníze vyfoukla (*jen* / *taky*) Eva.
 money stole only / also Eva
 'Only / Also Eva stole the money.'

The salience of properties (i) and (ii) has led some researchers to the conviction that the clausal demonstrative is in fact not a demonstrative, determiner, or pronoun at all. It has often been considered a particle or a discourse connective (McCoy 2001; 2002; Mírovský et al. 2017; Tajsner 2018). The aim of this article is to show that the demonstrative core is strong enough to substantiate an essentially demonstrative analysis. At the same time, I will suggest that the clausal demonstrative spells out left-peripheral heads, which in turn makes them akin to particles known from languages like Gungbe (Aboh 2004), Kikuyu (Schwarz 2007), Kĩĩtharaka (Abels & Muriungi 2008), Japanese (Vermeulen 2013), or Awing (Fominyam & Šimík 2017).

There are uses of demonstratives in Czech which could plausibly be considered "clausal", but which lack properties (i) and (ii) and hence fall outside of the scope of the present investigation. In examples (4), for instance, *to* is a propositional anaphor, referring back to a proposition which would naturally be expressed by a clause. Nevertheless, it does not count as a clausal demonstrative because it is inflected for case (cf. property (i)), see (4a) vs. (4b), and it is flexible in terms of placement (cf. property (ii)), behaving as a standard pronominal, or a nominal phrase, see (4a) vs. (4c) and (4d).

- (4) a. *To* Mirek určitě neřekl.
 DEM.ACC.SG.N Mirek surely NEG.said
 'Mirek surely didn't say that.'
- b. O *tom* Mirek určitě nemluvil.
 about DEM.LOC.SG.N Mirek surely NEG.spoke
 'Mirek surely didn't speak about that.'

- c. Mirek *to* určitě neřekl.
Mirek DEM.ACC.SG.N surely NEG.said
'Mirek surely didn't say that.'
- d. Mirek určitě neřekl jenom *to*.
Mirek surely NEG.said only DEM.ACC.SG.N
'Mirek surely didn't say only that.'

This type of demonstrative is also productive (although typically optional) as a nominalizer of embedded clauses of various types. As such, it can be adjacent to its CP complement or move on its own, stranding the CP complement; see (5a). The DEM + CP complex can also move as a constituent, and DEM can also participate in left-dislocation structures; see (5b). In these constructions, the demonstrative is not only positionally flexible (with the exception of left dislocation structures, where it must be clause-initial), but also inflected for case, as made explicit in (5c). The last example shows that the nominalized CP can be interrogative.

- (5) a. {*To*} Mirek {*to*} nezmínil {*to*}, že by měl hlad.
DEM.ACC.SG.N Mirek DEM NEG.mentioned DEM DECL.C SBJV.3 had hunger
'Mirek didn't mention that he was hungry.'
- b. (*To*) Že by měl hlad, (*to*) Mirek nezmínil.
DEM.ACC.SG.N DECL.C SBJV.3 had hunger DEM Mirek NEG.mentioned
'That he was hungry Mirek didn't mention.'
- c. Mirek přemýšlel (nad *tím*), jestli / proč Jitka odešla.
Mirek thought over DEM.INSTR.SG.N whether why Jitka left
'Mirek was wondering whether / why Jitka left.'

While interesting in their own right, these demonstratives remain outside of the scope of this study. For more discussion, I refer the reader to Roussou (1991); Moulton (2009); Haegeman & Ürögdi (2010); Kastner (2015); Knyazev (2016); Zimmermann (2021).

The last kind of demonstrative which is arguably closely related to the clausal demonstrative, but whose discussion goes beyond the scope of this paper, is what we could call the *wh*-related demonstrative. This type differs from all the above types in that it is not sentence- or clause-initial.² Nevertheless, it occupies a fixed position in a clause: it always directly follows second-position clitics, see (6a), or the fronted *wh*-phrase, if no clitics are present, see (6b). *Wh*-questions with the clausal demonstrative *to* are often naturally translated to English by cleft *wh*-questions, as in (6a), which suggests kinship with the focus-related demonstrative (section 2.2.2).

- (6) a. *Context*: 'What scammers!'
Co se mi *to* pokoušeli namluvit? [C]
what REFL me CDEM tried tell
'What was it that they were trying to tell me?'

² See example (i), modified from (6b):

- (i) **To* kde vlastně přesně jsme? [M]
CDEM where actually exactly are.1PL
Intended: 'Where are we exactly, actually?'

For completeness, I add that I have not been able to find a single example where *to* would precede a *wh*-word in the syn v14 corpus, indirectly supporting the ungrammaticality of (i).

- b. Kde *to* vlastně přesně jsme? [C]
 where CDEM actually exactly are.1PL
 ‘Where are we exactly, actually?’

The *wh*-related *to* can appear both in matrix questions, as above, and in embedded questions, as in (7a). It is, however, ungrammatical in relative clauses, even though they can be string-identical to the corresponding questions.

- (7) a. [...] musím přece vědět, kdo *to* ke mně přišel. [C]
 must PRT know who CDEM to me came
 ‘[...] I must know who (it is that) came to me.’
 b. Mirek byl ten, kdo (**to*) ke mně přišel. [M]
 Mirek was DEM who CDEM to me came
 (Intended:) ‘Mirek was the one who came to me.’

A deeper investigation of the relation between the clausal demonstrative and the *wh*-related demonstrative is left for future research. For some discussion, see Junghanns (1997); Šimík (2009); Yerbakov & Philippova (2023).

2.2 Clausal demonstrative uses

Turning back to the clausal demonstrative as defined above, I now sketch a basic descriptive typology of their uses: topic-related (section 2.2.1), focus-related (section 2.2.2), andthetic (section 2.2.3).

2.2.1 Topic-related demonstrative

A topic-related clausal demonstrative was illustrated in (2a). Two more examples are provided in (8). All the examples involve a contrastive topic followed by a focus later in the utterance, leading to the standard CT-F structure (Büring 2003).³

- (8) a. *Context:* Eliška is experiencing a relationship issue.
 To [VERA]_{CT} čelila úplně [JINÝM]_F problémům. [C]
 CDEM Vera faced completely different problems
 ‘Vera, on the other hand, faced completely different problems.’
 b. *Context:* In Tísek, they have no waste recycling site.
 To [V [...] HOSTAŠOVICÍCH]_{CT} novelu zákona [...] [SPLŇUJÍ]_F. [C]
 CDEM in Hostašovice amendment law fulfill
 ‘In Hostašovice, they do fulfill the law amendment.’

The topic obligatorily immediately follows the clause-initial demonstrative, as is evident from (9). One could argue that this requirement is not necessarily imposed by the clausal demonstrative, as topics are typically utterance-initial in Czech (Jasinskaja & Šimík forthcoming). However, the fact that the same holds for foci (see section 2.2.2) strongly suggests that the demonstrative is indeed responsible for this effect.

- (9) **To* novelu zákona [V HOSTAŠOVICÍCH]_{CT} [SPLŇUJÍ]_F. [M]
 CDEM amendment law in Hostašovice fulfill
 Intended: ‘In Hostašovice, they do fulfill the law amendment.’

³ Small caps are used to indicate prosodic prominence. While focus prominence is obligatory, contrastive topics are prosodically prominent only optionally (Veselá & Peterek & Hajičová 2003; Kořánová 2025).

Another salient property of this construction is that the contrastive topic relies on a contrasting antecedent in the immediately preceding discourse.⁴ In (8a) the topical individual Vera is contrasted with Eliška; in (8b), the town Hostašovice is contrasted with Tísek. Example (10) shows that this order must be retained: in a discourse prompting a series of CT-F utterances, *to* is ungrammatical in the initiating utterance, whereas it is optional in the subsequent one.⁵

- (10) *Context:* ‘How have have the towns put up with the amendment?’
 (**To*) [TÍSEK]_{CT} zatím žádný sběrný dvůr [NEMÁ]_F. (*To*) [HOSTAŠOVICE]_{CT}
 CDEM Tísek still no.NCI collecting yard NEG.has CDEM Hostašovice
 novelu [SPLŇUJÍ]_F. [M]
 amendment fulfills
 ‘Tísek doesn’t have a recycling site yet. Hostašovice (, on the other hand,) does fulfill the amendment.’

The last significant property of the topic-related clausal demonstrative is that it cannot be embedded or used in questions.

- (11) a. Tvrdili, že (**to*) [V HOSTAŠOVICÍCH]_{CT} novelu [splňují]_F. [M]
 told DECL.C CDEM in Hostašovice amendment fulfill
 (Intended:) ‘They claimed that, in Hostašovice, they do fulfill the amendment.’
 b. {A / **To*} [V HOSTAŠOVICÍCH]_{CT} novelu [splňují]_F? [M]
 and CDEM in Hostašovice amendment fulfill
 (Intended:) ‘And in Hostašovice, they do fulfill the amendment?’

2.2.2 Focus-related demonstrative

A focus-related clausal demonstrative was illustrated in (2b). Two more examples are provided in (12).

- (12) a. *To* [TIM]_F mu vnukl tu myšlenku [...], ne pan Simon. [C]
 CDEM Tim him gave DEM idea not Mr. Simon
 ‘It was TIM who gave him the idea, not Mr. Simon.’
 b. *To* [kvůli TOBĚ]_F přijdu o všechno, [...]. [C]
 CDEM because.of you come of everything
 ‘It’s because of YOU that I lose everything, [...]’

The focus (or, more precisely, the focus phrase; Krifka 2006) obligatorily immediately follows the clause-initial demonstrative; see (13). This is a non-trivial empirical point because the default (most frequent and most natural) position of foci – regardless of their type (new, contrastive, etc.) – is clause-final (Sgall & Hajičová & Buráňová 1980; Jasinskaja & Šimík forthcoming; Staňková et al. 2025).

⁴ In the corpus search, 55 out of 59 (93 %) randomly selected instances of topic-related *to* involved an explicit contrasting antecedent for the topic.

⁵ I note that this behavior of *to* is consistent with the idea that it is a paratactic discourse connective. As such, it can only connect two propositions or utterances such that one precedes the connective and the other follows it. In my analysis, discourse connectivity is not a primitive; it follows from *to* being an anaphoric demonstrative.

- (13) **To* přijdu o všechno [kvůli TOBĚ]_F. [M]
 CDEM come of everything because.of you
 Intended: ‘It’s because of YOU that I lose everything, [...]’

In contrast with the topic-related demonstrative, focus-related *to* appears to be less contextually dependent and more prone to accommodation. In both examples below, the background of the focus (what follows *to* + FOCUS) represents new, not given information. Despite that, it is typically construed as being associated in one way or another with immediately preceding context: in (14a) Laura’s holding her [Sarah’s] hand during childbirth is associated with (but not entailed by) Laura being helpful in the past; in (14b), London refusing to give the crown to Matilda and handing it over to Stephen is associated with (but not entailed by) London’s having a significant say in England’s affairs and supporting monarchs.⁶ This relatively loose association is sufficient for the background to be deaccented, which is normally – in other grammatical environments – not possible with non-given information in Czech. I further point out that the focused constituent can be contrasted with a contextually present alternative (in (14a), Laura is contrasted with Sarah’s husband), but not necessarily so (in (14b), London is not contrasted with any other power center).

- (14) a. *Context*: ‘It was Sarah’s girlfriend [Laura] who wiped her tears in the hospital, while her Sarah’s husband wept in the car.’
To [LAURA]_F ji držela za ruku, když porodila své první dítě, [...] [C]
 CDEM Laura her held on hand when bore her first child
 ‘It was LAURA who held her hand when she gave birth to her first child, [...]’
- b. *Context*: ‘London was determined to have a significant say in the affairs of England. When London supported the monarch, it was always a win.’
To [LONDÝN]_F odmítl dát Matyldě korunu a předal ji Štěpánovi.
 CDEM London refused give Matilda crown and handed.over it Stephen
 [C]
 ‘It was London that refused to give Matilda the crown and handed it over to Stephen.’

Finally, I would like to point out that the focus in this type of construction is naturally construed as exhaustive: the focus is implied to be the only (contextually relevant) element which satisfies the background. All of the 58 corpus cases are consistent with an exhaustive focus interpretation; in none do we see evidence to the contrary. An extra corpus search reveals many examples in which the focus is associated with the exclusive particle *jen* ‘only’, which is consistent with the construction’s exhaustivity. One such example is provided in (15a). By contrast, examples of *to* followed by the additive particle *taky* ‘also’ are essentially absent in corpus. The only example I have managed to find is (15b), where, however, *taky* is naturally construed not as a focus particle associating with the focus, but rather as ‘by the way’, or perhaps ‘I could also add that...’.⁷

- (15) a. *Context*: ‘Children can be pretty mean.’

⁶ In the auxiliary corpus search, 24 out of 58 (41 %) cases of focus-related *to* are like examples (14) in that the background is not, strictly speaking, given.

⁷ From 75 randomly selected cases of clausal demonstratives followed by *jen* ‘only’ (of which thousands of occurrences are available), 35 (47 %) are cases of focus-related demonstratives. Clausal demonstratives directly followed by *taky* ‘also’ are rather rare. I have been able to identify 8 such cases, only one of which was followed by a focus (see the discussion of example (15b)).

- To jen [JEŽÍŠ]_F si myslel, že děti jsou dobrý. [C]
 CDEM only Jesus REFL thought C.DECL children are good
 ‘It’s only Jesus who thought children were good.’
- b. *Context:* ‘We fought.’
 To taky [kvůli NĚMU]_F vypadám takhle. [C]
 CDEM also because.of him look.like this
- (i) Natural: ‘It is, by the way, because of him [the person I fought with] that I look like this.’
 (ii) Unlikely: ‘It is also because of him [the person I fought with] that I look like this.’

The last point to note is that focus-related clausal demonstrative can be embedded, see (16a), and can be used in questions, see (16b).

- (16) a. [...] také mu vyčetla, že to [kvůli NĚMU]_F opustila práci ve
 also him blamed C.DECL CDEM because.of him left job in
 městě [...] [C]
 city
 ‘She also blamed him that it was because of him that she left her job in the city.’
- b. To [s NÍM]_F jsi měla všechny ty tajný schůzky? [C]
 CDEM with him AUX.2SG had all DEM secret meetings
 ‘It was him that you had all the secret meetings with?’

2.2.3 Thetic demonstratives

What I call here a thetic clausal demonstratives (a term inspired by Kimmelman 2009) possibly represents a relatively diverse set of clausal demonstrative subtypes which all exhibit the definitional properties listed in section 2.1 and which at the same time do not associate with a contrastive topic or focus.⁸ Two examples of the most frequent and productive subtype are provided in (17). There is no straightforward translation of these demonstratives to English. I translate them by a postponed *then*, which seems to me to capture the implication they convey in this case: the proposition followed by *to* is construed as the consequent of a contextually recoverable antecedent, not unlike in a conditional construction – ‘if that’s the case, then *p*’.

- (17) a. *Context:* ‘This is Mr. Piper from America.’
 To k nám vážil hodně dlouhou cestu. [C]
 CDEM to us came very long way
 ‘He came a very long way to us, then.’
- b. *Context:* ‘I can shoot you like a deer [ironically].’
 To z tebe budou mít tvoji noví kamarádi v partaji radost. [C]
 CDEM of you will have your new friends from party happiness
 ‘Your new friends from the party will be happy with you, then.’

Both examples above are string-identical to potential topic- or focus-related uses, from which they are distinguished prosodically: while topic- and focus-related uses would

⁸ Some of the uses have been discussed in Kolářová (2003; 2009), who also investigated the potential competitions/synonymy of *to* with other expressions, such as *tak* ‘so’, which is common in the sense of *then* as used in conditional consequents.

involve prosodic prominence on the constituent which immediately follows *to* (and, in case of topic, an additional focus-related prominence later in the utterance), the thetic use is characterized by neutral prosody associated with broad focus. Example (18) shows more clearly a structural characteristic which is not shared by topic- or focus-related uses: because the demonstrative does not have to be followed by a topical or focal phrase, it can be followed directly by prosodically weak second-position clitics, manifested in (18) by the reflexive clitic *se*.

- (18) *Context: ‘Did I really speak so pathetically?’*
To se zpětně omlouvám. [C]
 CDEM REFL in.retrospect apologize
 ‘I apologize in retrospect, then.’

Finally, I note that while thetic demonstratives can be used in questions, see (19), I have not come across an example where it would appear in an embedded clause.

- (19) *Context: ‘Every morning I see retired people queuing at the post office, waiting for pension payment.’*
To do té fronty budu muset také? [C]
 CDEM in DEM line will must too
 ‘Will I also have to queue there, then?’

3 Analysis

The central question of this article is to what extent the clausal demonstrative can be analyzed as an ordinary demonstrative. I will argue for a deep semantic parallelism between the clausal and the nominal demonstrative, building on the idea that the core function of a demonstrative is to relate the meaning of its nominal/clausal argument to a contextually salient discourse referent of the same semantic type. In the case of the clausal demonstrative, this means relating the demonstrative’s propositional argument to another contextually salient proposition. This semantics is crucially aided by the clausal demonstrative’s syntax. In order for the demonstrative to select a propositional complement, I argue that it “teams up” with standardly assumed left-peripheral heads: Fin, Foc, and Top. The heads involved in the structure determine the use of the demonstrative – thetic, focus-related, and topic-related, respectively. Adopting a nanosyntactic treatment of the clausal demonstrative, I argue for a single lexical entry incorporating all the heads and capable of spelling out the respective structural subsets.

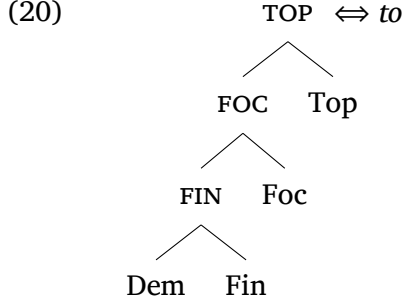
In the remainder of this section, I first discuss the morphosyntactic aspects of the analysis (section 3.1), then I turn to the semantic analysis, including the analysis of the individual types of the clausal demonstratives (section 3.2), and finally, I discuss some predictions of the analysis (section 3.3).

3.1 Morphosyntax

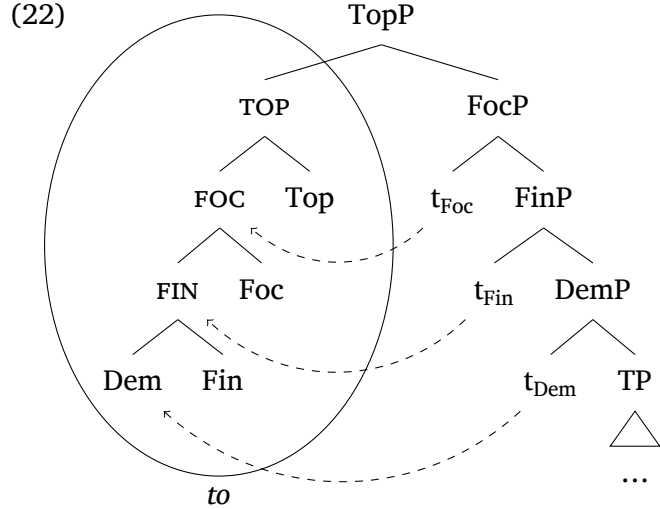
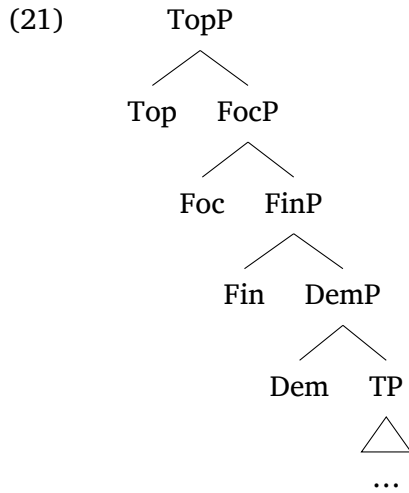
Building on the core assumptions of the nanosyntactic framework (Starke 2009; Baunaz & Lander 2018; De Clercq et al. 2026), I propose that the clausal demonstrative *to* lexically encodes the structure in (20).⁹ Besides being a demonstrative with predictable demonstrative semantics, the clausal demonstrative is thus closely related to left-peripheral

⁹ I use small caps to indicate a complex syntactic head.

information structural markers, known from many typologically diverse languages (McCoy 2001; Aboh 2004; Schwarz 2007; Abels & Muriungi 2008; Tomioka 2010b; Yasavul 2013; Fominyam & Šimík 2017; Xu & Liu 2026; among many others).

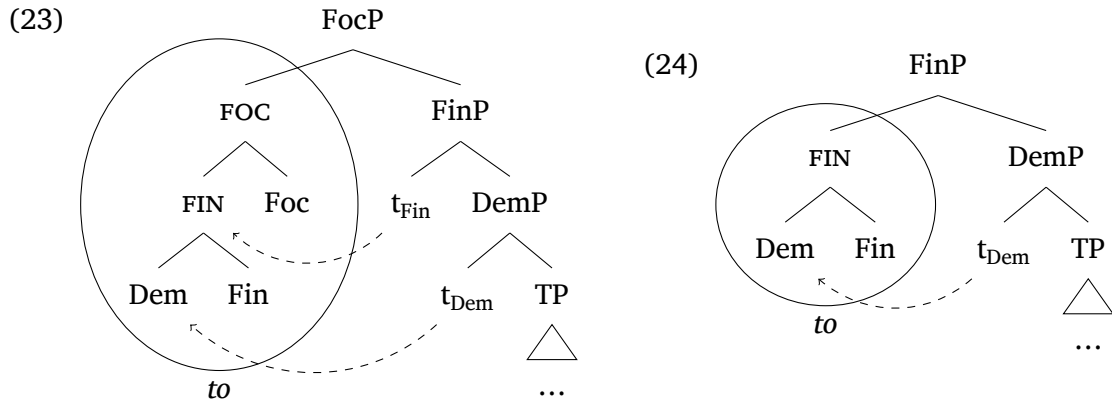


The structure in (20) can be derived from the standardly assumed base structure (21) (Rizzi 1997; et seq.) by head movement, as illustrated in (22).¹⁰ The lexical entry for *to* matches the constituent formed and *to* can therefore lexicalize it. As shown in (23), *to* can also lexicalize subsets of the lexically encoded structure, specifically FOC or FIN, as per the nanosyntactic Identity Condition on Matching (De Clercq et al. 2025; 2026), also known as the Superset Principle.¹¹



¹⁰ Here I call upon head movement mainly for expository reasons. In the nanosyntactic framework, head movement does not exist, but a comparable effect can be achieved by the subderivation mechanism, representing the last (resort) step in the lexicalization algorithm proposed by Starke (2018) (see also Wiland 2019, Caha & De Clercq & Vanden Wyngaerd 2025, and the chapters therein). Alternatively, the heads could remain in situ and the spell-out could be based on spanning (Abels & Muriungi 2008; Ramchand 2008; Dékány 2009; Blix 2021; Biskup 2026), i.e., a joint spell-out of a contiguous sequence of heads without the requirement for them to form a constituent.

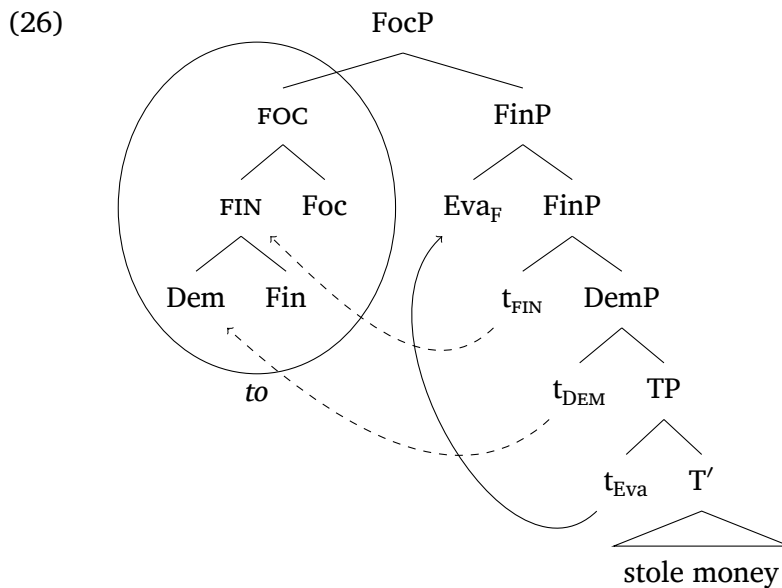
¹¹ There is nothing in the syntax or lexicalization process that would prohibit the lexicalization of DEM alone. I assume, however, that this would fail for semantic reasons: the Fin head is needed to specify CDEM's arguments to a propositional type.



All the lexicalization options are summarized in (25), along with their attribution to the clausal demonstrative subtypes.

- (25) *Structures lexicalizable by the clausal demonstrative to*
- | | |
|--|-----------------------|
| a. $[_{TOP} \text{ FOC Top}] \Rightarrow to$ | topic-related CDEM |
| b. $[_{FOC} \text{ FIN Foc}] \Rightarrow to$ | focus/wh-related CDEM |
| c. $[_{FIN} \text{ Dem Fin}] \Rightarrow to$ | thetic CDEM |

The topic- and the focus-related CDEM involve obligatory movement of a contrastive topic or focus, respectively, to a position immediately following the CDEM. I propose to model this as A-bar movement plus adjunction to the sister of the complement of the head. This is illustrated in (26), the proposed structural description of (2b), for focus movement, which targets the sister position of FinP – the complement of Foc. An analogous structure is assumed for the movement of contrastive topics, which adjoin to FocP – the complement of Top (not illustrated here). No such movement occurs in thetic CDEM constructions, as Fin is not information-structure sensitive.



This movement does not achieve a Spec-Head relationship between the licensing head (FOC) and the associated phrase (*Eva*), as commonly assumed in the cartographic / crite-

rial freezing approach (Rizzi 1997; 2006).¹² However, it is designed to achieve the same effect by different means: the focused phrase lands in a position where it is the closest element c-commanded by the head.¹³ This is a configuration commonly observed for the relation between focus-sensitive particles and their associated phrases (see, e.g., Jacobs 1983; Büring & Hartmann 2001; Erlewine 2017; Fominyam & Šimík 2017) and follows from the Closeness Principle in (27).¹⁴

- (27) *Closeness Principle* (Büring & Hartmann 2001: 237)
Focus particles are as close to the focus as possible.

Fominyam & Šimík (2017) argue that there are two ways to satisfy Closeness: either the particle is flexible in terms of its attachment (as argued by Büring & Hartmann 2001 for German focus particles like *nur* ‘only’ or by Erlewine 2017 for the Vietnamese *chỉ* ‘only’), allowing for positional flexibility of the associated phrase, or it is not (as in the case of the Awing exhaustive particle *lá*, discussed in detail in Fominyam & Šimík 2017), in which case it is the phrase that must move to the position required. As discussed in section 2.1 (see example (3)), the clausal demonstrative has a grammatically fixed position, and so is of the latter type. I further assume that the same configuration is required for the association of *to* with the contrastive topic. That focus and contrastive topic behave alike in certain respects is expected, given their semantic similarity, i.e., the activation of alternatives (Rooth 1992; Büring 2003), which in turn has led to unified analyses (see, e.g., Tomioka 2010a; Wagner 2012; Constant 2014).

The present proposal predicts that the clausal demonstrative can be embedded and used in questions, at least to the extent that embedding and question semantics are encoded in the Force projection, which is located above the Top-Foc-Fin sequence (for relevant discussion about Russian, see Junghanns 1997). As I showed in section 2.2, this prediction is basically borne out forthetic and focus-related uses, but not for the topic-related demonstrative (section 2.2.1). The fact that the topic-related CDEM cannot be embedded could be interpreted in two ways consistent with my analysis. The first possibility is that the topic-related CDEM spells out not just the Top-Foc-Fin-Dem sequence, but the Force-Top-Foc-Fin-Dem sequence, thereby making it impossible for Force to be spelled out by other elements, such as complementizers or question operators. This would require adapting the lexical entry for the Czech CDEM and it would raise the question whether the structure Top-Foc-Fin-Dem (without Force) can also be spelled out, and if not, then why not. The second possibility is to assume that the topic-related CDEM obligatorily associates with a specific type of force. It has occasionally been observed in the literature that (certain types of) contrastive topics resist embedding, which in turn was interpreted in terms of an interaction with speech act syntax/semantics (e.g. Jacobs 1997; Tomioka 2010b; Wagner 2012). I have shown in section 2.2.1 that contrastive topics without the CDEM can be used in polar questions (see also Staňková 2026) and arguably can also be embedded in some types of embedded clauses, so the embedding restriction must be due

¹² This is not to say that the Spec-Head relation is not relevant in other, possibly very related cases. See section 4 for a brief discussion of the Russian counterpart of the Czech topic-related CDEM, which appears to require the Spec-Head relationship.

¹³ This means that the movement is not feature-driven. From the perspective of narrow syntax, it is optional; it is only required at LF where F-marking (or CT-marking) becomes relevant. I refer the reader to Fominyam & Šimík (2017) for more in-depth discussion.

¹⁴ Büring & Hartmann’s approach has been criticized (see, e.g., Reis 2005; Smeets & Wagner 2017). However, the criticism only applies to particles which are positionally flexible and at the same time can be analyzed as attaching directly to the focus, which is difficult to maintain for the Czech clausal demonstrative (see section 2.1). See also Erlewine (2017) for discussion.

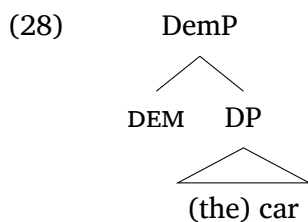
to the topic-related CDEM. Aware of the analytical options, I leave this issue open for future research.

3.2 Compositional semantics

The gist of my proposal is that the clausal demonstrative is essentially just a demonstrative adapted to selecting clauses/propositions at a suitable structural level – a plain proposition (thetic demonstrative), a proposition with activated focus alternatives (focus-related demonstrative), and a proposition with activated topic alternatives (topic-related demonstrative). In order to appreciate the proposal, I first go through the essence of demonstrative semantics shared by most recent analyses (Elbourne 2008; Schwarz 2009; Simonenko 2014; Ahn 2019; Nowak 2021; Jenks & Konate 2022; a.o.).

Informally said, the semantic/pragmatic function of a demonstrative is to relate the denotation of its syntactic complement to a salient discourse referent. The discourse referent is typically of the same semantic type and the relation is typically one of identity. For instance, an expression like *this car* relates ‘the car’ – the denotation of *this*’s complement – to a salient referent, such as a previously mentioned car or a car pointed at.¹⁵

In more formal terms, a demonstrative comes with two indices – i and j in (29) – such that one index maps to an entity of the same semantic type as DEM’s argument (i.e., type e ; y in (29)) and the other maps to a relation between the two entities (i.e., type $\langle e, \langle e, t \rangle \rangle$; R in (29)). The demonstrative presupposes that R holds between y and the demonstrative’s argument (x) and returns the demonstrative’s argument (x) as the value. The value of both indices is provided by the assignment function g and the mapping is assumed to be part of the discourse knowledge shared by the interlocutors. The value of the entity (y) either follows from previous discourse (anaphoric uses) or from a pointing gesture (exophoric/deictic uses). The value of the relation (R) is typically the identity relation, as in (29a), but not necessarily – see (29b).



- (29) $\llbracket \text{DEM}_{i,j} \rrbracket^{g[i \rightarrow R, j \rightarrow y]} = \lambda x : [R(x, y)].x$ (relating x)
- Typical use: y = a previously mentioned car / a car pointed at; R = ‘is identical with’
 - Less typical use: y = a garage pointed at; R = ‘parks in’ (deferred ostension; cf. Nunberg 1993; Elbourne 2008)

3.2.1 The thetic demonstrative

I argue that the function of a clausal demonstrative is analogous to the function of a nominal demonstrative: It relates the denotation of its syntactic complement to a salient discourse referent. The role of Fin is to change the semantic type of the demonstrative’s

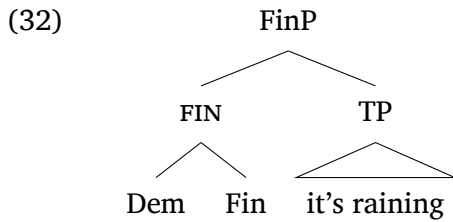
¹⁵ I assume that the demonstrative itself is not responsible for shifting the semantic type of its complement from $\langle e, t \rangle$ to e . The shift is achieved by a D head (corresponding to the definite article) which the demonstrative may but need not co-lexicalize; see Šimík (2016) for discussion.

argument to a proposition. In other words, Fin makes Dem into a CDEM. The type of both indices is also changed accordingly. This results in the meaning (30).

$$(30) \quad \llbracket \text{FIN}_{i,j} \rrbracket^{g[i \rightarrow R, j \rightarrow p']} = \lambda p : R(p, p') . p$$

This meaning produces the correct result (a proposition), while at the same time presupposing that the proposition is in relation R (value of i) to another proposition p' (value of j). This, I argue, is a plausible analytical substrate for the thetic demonstrative, a simple example of which is provided in (31), along with its simplified structural description in (32) and compositional semantics in (33).

- (31) To prší.
CDEM rains
'[What's happening is that] It's raining.'



- (33) a. $\llbracket \text{TP} \rrbracket = \lambda w [\text{RAINS}(w)]$
 b. $\llbracket \text{FIN}_{i,j} \rrbracket^{g[i \rightarrow R, j \rightarrow p']} (\lambda w [\text{RAINS}(w)])$
 (i) is defined iff $\lambda w [\text{RAINS}(w)]$ is in relation R to the proposition p' ; if defined, then it equals
 (ii) $\lambda w [\text{RAINS}(w)]$

A situation in which (31) is felicitously uttered is when the interlocutors hear sounds which raise an (implicit or explicit) question 'What's happening?', 'What's the source of the sound?', or the like, and where the proposition 'It's raining' is identical with the assumed answer to that question. In this case, the relation is one of identity (arguably the default relation implied by demonstratives) and the proposition with which the preja-cent is identical is to the answer to a salient question – also known as a question under discussion (QUD).

As discussed in section 2.2.3, thetic demonstratives are typically used with clauses construed as consequent clauses of implicit conditional antecedents. An example of this use is (17a), repeated in (34) with an adapted translation.

- (34) *Context:* 'This is Mr. Piper from America.'
 To k nám vážil hodně dlouhou cestu. [C]
 CDEM to us came very long way
 '[If he is from America, then] He came a very long way to us.'

In these uses, the denotation of the complement of the clausal demonstrative (p) is arguably not 'identical to' (R) the implied propositional discourse antecedent (p'). Rather, the implied relation is one between a conditional antecedent (p') and its consequent (p). Assuming standard Kratzerian conditional semantics (see Kratzer 1986; 2012), the relation could be captured as in (35), where the antecedent p' co-restricts the implicit modal quantifier and where ACC is a contextually appropriate accessibility relation.

$$(35) \quad \lambda p' \lambda p \lambda w \forall w' [\text{ACC}(w, w') \wedge p'(w') \rightarrow p(w)]$$

A situation where the implied relation is not one of identity is technically a case of deferred ostension, which is a general interpretive option for demonstratives; cf. (29b).

3.2.2 Focus-related demonstrative

I propose that the focus-related demonstrative maintains the demonstrative semantics (contribution of Dem) applied to propositions (contribution of Fin) and, in addition, it makes use of the focus semantics of its complement. The overall semantics of clauses introduced by CDEM + focus corresponds to that of English *it*-clefts: it conveys that the complement of CDEM equals what could be called the “maximal true alternative”, i.e., the alternative that entails all the other true alternatives. Even though cleft semantics and pragmatics is a rather complex issue (for recent discussion, see, e.g., Velleman et al. 2012; Büring & Križ 2013; De Veauugh-Geiss et al. 2018; Amiraz 2024), the existence of such an alternative is a standardly assumed presupposition of clefts, which is sometimes referred to as the exhaustiveness presupposition.^{16,17} The implied identity relation (*R*) between the asserted proposition (*p*) and the presupposed alternative (*p'*) follows the general format of demonstrative semantics, which in turn naturally motivates the use of demonstratives in cleft constructions. In addition to the demonstrative semantics, applied to propositions, FOC functions as a focus operator in the sense of Rooth’s (1992) squiggle, i.e., it contributes an additional variable (*k* below) which maps to a contextually salient set of propositions which are a subset of the focus semantic value of FOC’s complement.¹⁸

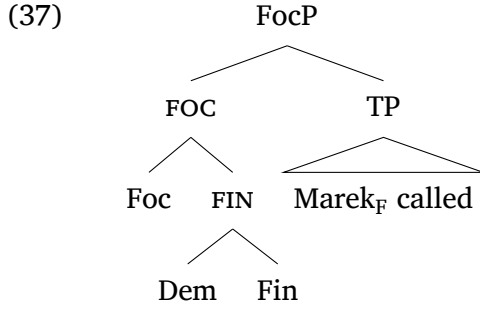
Let us apply the analysis to example (36), with the corresponding structural description in (37) and the compositional semantics in (38). The sentence is true if Marek called and if the proposition that Marek called is identical to the maximal true proposition in the contextually salient and restricted set of alternatives of the form ‘*x* called’. If this set is, for instance, {‘Marek called’, ‘Lisa called’, ‘Marek and Lisa called’} and if ‘Marek called’ is the maximal true alternative, the sentence entails that ‘Lisa called’ and ‘Marek and Lisa called’ are false.

- (36) To MAREK_F volal.
CDEM Marek called
‘It was Marek who called.’

¹⁶ Most existing accounts of clefts assume the structured proposition approach, in which the focus is directly compositionally accessible. As a result, the relevant presupposition is usually formulated in terms of the existence of a (maximal) entity that makes the background true. My approach crucially builds on propositional alternatives (whence “(maximal) true alternative”, but has the required expressive power.

¹⁷ There is an ongoing debate (also in the literature cited) concerning the nature of the presupposition: is it an exhaustiveness (or, maximality), or a simply an existence presupposition? As correctly pointed out by Büring & Križ (2013), however, the debate is vacuous in the sense that the (weaker) existence presupposition entails maximality: the existence of a true alternative entails the existence of a maximal true alternative.

¹⁸ To remain fully within the realm of Rooth’s account, one could assume that the variable *k* (mapping to a salient set of propositions) is not directly contributed by FOC, but that the use of FOC triggers the insertion of $\sim_k$.



- (38)
- a. (i) $\llbracket TP \rrbracket_o = \lambda w[\text{CALLED}(\text{MAREK})(w)]$
 - (ii) $\llbracket TP \rrbracket_f = \{\lambda w[\text{CALLED}(x)(w)] \mid x \in D_e\}$
 - b. (i) $\llbracket \text{FOC}_{i,j,k} TP \rrbracket_o^{g[i \rightarrow R, j \rightarrow p', k \rightarrow C]}$
 - 1. is defined iff $\lambda w[\text{CALLED}(\text{MAREK})(w)]$ is in relation R (here: is identical to) p' , such that $p' \in C$, $C \subseteq \llbracket TP \rrbracket_f$, $\forall q[q \in C \wedge q(w) = 1 \rightarrow p \subseteq q]$; if defined, then it equals
 - 2. $\lambda w[\text{CALLED}(\text{MAREK})(w)]$
 - (ii) $\llbracket \text{FOC}_{i,j,k} TP \rrbracket_f^{g[i \rightarrow R, j \rightarrow p', k \rightarrow C]} = \{\lambda w[\text{CALLED}(\text{MAREK})(w)]\}$

I take this to be an adequate adaptation of existing cleft analyses to my own analytical assumptions – specifically the demonstrative semantics. I am aware that the semantic analyses I build on face empirical problems, especially the failure to detect the predicted clear exhaustivity of clefts experimentally (see, e.g., [Destruel 2012](#); [Pavlou & Leivada & Papadopoulou 2013](#); [De Veugh-Geiss et al. 2018](#)). I suspect that these problems will carry over to the Czech demonstrative-based cleft (although see the corpus facts discussed in 2.2.2). I take the reconciliation of the theoretical analyses with experimental results to be a broader challenge to be tackled in future research.

3.2.3 Topic-related demonstrative

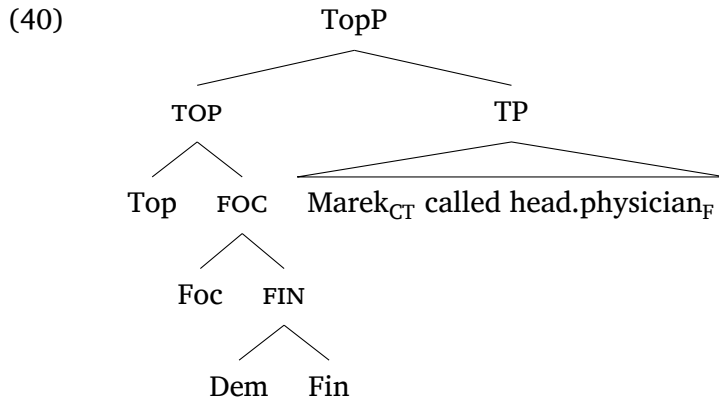
The topic-related demonstrative, again, builds on the contributions of the containing heads. The Top head contributes an extra level of meaning – the (contrastive) topic semantic value ([Büring 2003](#)) – a set of sets of propositional alternatives, corresponding to a multiple question (like ‘Who called who?’). Like the previously discussed kinds of the clausal demonstrative, topic CDEM – or TOP for short – relates (R) the proposition denoted by its complement (p) to another proposition (p'). It follows from the empirical observations in section 2.2.1 that in this case, the relation between p and p' is not one of identity. Instead, p and p' both address a different subquestion of the same superquestion (topic semantic value); in other words, p and p' are both *about* a different (contrastive) topic.¹⁹

The analysis is applied to a specific example below. The utterance in (39) is felicitously used, for instance, in a situation where someone has just said that Jitka called a doctor, thus making the proposition ‘Jitka called a doctor’ (p' in (41)) contextually salient. From the perspective of (39), Jitka is the contrastive topic of p' , which addresses the question ‘Who did Jitka call?’ (Q' in (41)), which (just like the question ‘Who did Marek

¹⁹ The word *about* is used in a terminological sense, i.e., in the sense of aboutness topics, whereby a topic is defined as (the constituent denoting) the referent (or more generally the denotation) which the proposition is *about* ([Reinhart 1981](#)). I consider a contrastive topic to be a special case (and perhaps the only case; cf. [Büring 2016](#)) of the aboutness topic.

call?', addressed by (39)) is a member of the topic semantic value (41a-ii), which in turn corresponds to the question 'Who called who?'.

- (39) To MAREK_{CT} volal PRIMÁŘI_F.
 CDEM Marek called head.physician
 '(In contrast,) Marek called the head physician.'



- (41) a. (i) $\llbracket TP \rrbracket_o = \lambda w[\text{CALLED}(\text{MAREK})(\iota z \text{ HEAD PHYSICIAN}(z))(w)]$
 (ii) $\llbracket TP \rrbracket_t = \{\{\lambda w[\text{CALLED}(x)(y)(w)] \mid y \in D_e\} \mid x \in D_e\}$
 b. (i) $\llbracket TOP_{i,j,k} TP \rrbracket_o^{g[i \rightarrow R, j \rightarrow p', k \rightarrow C]}$
 1. is defined iff $\lambda w[\text{CALLED}(\text{MAREK})(\iota z \text{ HEAD PHYSICIAN}(z))(w)]$ (p for short) is in relation R to a contextually salient p' , such that $\exists Q, Q' \in \llbracket TP \rrbracket_t, Q \neq Q', p \in Q$ and $p' \in Q'$; if defined, then it equals
 2. $\lambda w[\text{CALLED}(\text{MAREK})(\iota z \text{ HEAD PHYSICIAN}(z))(w)]$
 (ii) $\llbracket TOP_{i,j,k} TP \rrbracket_t^{g[i \rightarrow R, j \rightarrow p', k \rightarrow C]}$
 $= \{\{\lambda w[\text{CALLED}(\text{MAREK})(\iota z \text{ HEAD PHYSICIAN}(z))(w)]\}\}$

3.2.4 Discussion

The semantic analysis just proposed has both a certain explanatory power and some notable elements of stipulation. The explanatory power dwells in the use of the demonstrative core: the establishment of a suitable relation (R) between the propositional denotation of CDEM's complement (p) and a contextually salient proposition (p'). The stipulative part consists in the values of R and p' in the individual CDEM types. Why, for instance, does the focus-related demonstrative imply the identity relation to the maximal true proposition (thereby introducing the exhaustivity presupposition), and not some other relation and some other proposition? Why does the topic-related demonstrative involve a relation to a proposition with a different topic?

Let us start with the focus-related demonstrative. Researchers working on focus within the alternative semantics framework have frequently noted the general tendency for focused constituents to be interpreted exhaustively, even in the absence of any lexical (focus-sensitive particles) or constructional (clefts) marking; this has led to semantic (vs. pragmatic) accounts, whereby the exhaustivity is triggered by a covert operator EXH inserted by default in the syntactic structure of clauses (see, e.g., Chierchia & Fox & Spector 2011; Chierchia 2013; Bade 2016). The experimental results of Schreiber & Onea (2021) suggest that participants interpreting sentences with narrow focus (i.e., focus on an argument) with no extra marking consider the exhaustive interpretation highly likely (with a likelihood higher than 80 %). On the other hand, explicit experimental comparisons with

focus associated with the particle ‘only’ suggest a pragmatic (i.e., conversational, rather than semantic/conventional) source of the exhaustivity of both prosodic (unmarked) focus and focus in clefts (see, e.g., [De Veaugh-Geiss et al. 2018](#)). I suggest that the default status of exhaustivity – whether its source is syntactic/semantic or pragmatic – makes the maximal true alternative in an alternative set particularly salient. In other words, the maximal true alternative enjoys a special status among all other alternatives and can thus be assumed to be generally available for being picked up in discourse. The exhaustive interpretation of the proffered alternative in clefts then follows from being equated with the contextually salient maximal true alternative.

As for the topic-related demonstrative, the reasoning can be as follows. The primary function of contrastive topics is to indicate a complex strategy of questions under discussion – one question per each relevant topic in ([Roberts 1996; 2012; Büring 2003](#)). The use of a (contrastive) topic thus entails the existence of at least one other proposition about a different topic. I would argue that this contrastive topic-related entailment is at the heart of the use of such a proposition in the semantics of the demonstrative.

What remains to be addressed is why the focus-related demonstrative and the topic-related demonstrative differ rather dramatically in their anaphoric potential. As discussed in section 2.2, the absolute majority of topic-related demonstratives refer back to a recently mentioned (proposition about a) contrasting topic (see fn. 4), while only about half of the focus-related demonstratives involves reference back to a background that generates the set of alternatives based on which the maximal true alternative is established (see fn. 6). In other words, the propositional antecedent of the topic-related demonstrative must already be established, whereas it can relatively easily be accommodated in the focus-related use. Where does this difference stem from? Consider the focus-related demonstrative first. In this case, the alternative set that deterministically generates the maximal true alternative is a subset of the focus semantic value of the propositional complement of CDEM. All that is required is, therefore, accommodating an appropriate contextual restriction, restricting the focus semantic value to a relevant subset of alternatives. This type of accommodation is commonly employed in the use of natural languages (see, e.g., [Stanley & Szabó 2000](#)). The situation with topic-related demonstratives is markedly different. There is no deterministic way of accommodating a specific (communicatively non-trivial) proposition about a contrasting topic from the topic semantic value of CDEM’s complement. As a result, the requirement for there to be a specific proposition in the context that could serve as a suitable antecedent for the topic-related demonstrative is much stronger.

Finally, let us briefly consider thethetic demonstratives. In section 3.2.1 I discussed two ways in which the propositional antecedent and the relation can be resolved. One was very similar to what happens in focus-related demonstratives: the context supplied a question (a set of propositional alternatives), thereby also the maximal true answer to the question, with which the proposition denoted by CDEM’s complement was equated. (The difference from the focus-related alternative is that the focus is on the whole proposition, as one would expect from thetic utterances.) The other frequent type of resolution is to the implicit antecedent to which the CDEM’s complement provides a consequent. It turns out that the latter type of resolution is a subcase of a broader family of cases where the clausal demonstrative supplies a relation commonly expressed by clausal or discourse connectives. Other such cases involve a temporal relation (p' before/during p , commonly expressed by ‘when’/‘after’-clauses) or a causal relation (p' cause of/caused

by *p*, commonly expressed by ‘because’-clauses).²⁰ I do not have a deeper insight about this beyond noting that it does indeed seem to make sense that a relation between propositions corresponds to what is commonly conveyed by connectives.

Notably, the Czech thetic demonstrative does not seem to afford the kind of construals reported by Wespel (2008) for Haitian Creole or by Owusu (2022) for Akan clausal determiners. They both propose that the clausal determiner takes a proposition as an argument, as I do here, but with quite a different result. Wespel (2008) argues that the determiner in Haitian Creole contributes factivity, so that a structure like [[Mary has left] DEF] means ‘Mary has left, as we knew.’ (from Lefebvre 1998: 238)). No such presupposition is conveyed by the Czech thetic clausal demonstrative, which, quite to the contrary, reports the propositional complement as a new piece of information. Owusu’s (2022) analysis of the Akan (clausal) determiner *nó* is closer to mine in that it does not postulate factivity, but rather familiarity, modeled as a presupposition that there is a propositional antecedent (semantically identical to the determiner’s prejacent). In her account, the antecedent must be a member of the “common propositional space” (the set of propositions of which the interlocutors are mutually aware, but which are not necessarily considered true; Portner 2007). To give a more specific example, the Akan structure [[Kofi has gone to see Dr. Abrefa] CD] (where CD = clausal determiner) is claimed by Owusu to presuppose that ‘Kofi going to see Dr. Abrefa’ had already been under discussion (e.g. in the sense of a recommendation from Kofi’s parents). No such presupposition is triggered by the Czech thetic demonstrative.²¹ The differences among Haitian, Akan, and Czech, or, for that matter, between any two languages with clausal determiners gives rise to an important research question that is yet to be addressed.

3.3 Predictions

In this section I discuss a number of specific predictions that my analysis makes and show how they are borne out.

The focus- and topic-related demonstrative is an instance of an information structure-sensitive particle in the sense that it crucially makes use of the focus/topic semantic value of its complement. As opposed to most such particles, however, the clausal demonstrative is necessarily clause-initial (see section 2.1). I have argued that this property of the clausal demonstrative follows from the assumption that it spells out left-peripheral (information structure-related) heads. The analysis predicts that the position concerns not only the overt realization of the demonstrative, but also its semantic scope: the demonstrative necessarily scopes over the TP it attaches to. Consider the contrast between (42a) and (42b). While the focus-sensitive operator *jenom* ‘only’, associating with a long-distance extracted object, is compatible with scope over the whole sentence, (42a-i), and scope over the embedded clause only, (42a-ii) (arguably an instance of the so-called Taglicht ambiguity, used as an argument that ‘only’ can attach to the focused phrase, move with it and thus scope in different positions; cf. Taglicht 1984), the focus-related CDEM in (42b) is only compatible with scope over the whole sentence, which follows from the assumption that the clausal demonstrative is not a particle with flexible attachment, but indeed a left-peripheral element with a fixed position and scope.

²⁰ The temporal, and possibly also the causal relation might call for a reconsideration of the idea that the relation implicated by the thetic demonstrative is always between two *propositions*; what one might need instead are *events*. I leave this issue for future research.

²¹ Curiously, Owusu’s interpretation is achieved in Czech by using a *nominal* rather than a *clausal* demonstrative. For more on this use of nominal demonstratives, see Šimík (2016).

- (42) a. *Jenom* [PETRA]_F říkali, že pozvali.
 only Petr.ACC said.3PL C.DECL invited.3PL
 ‘They said that they invited only Petr.’
 (i) Possible entailment: ‘They didn’t say that they invited anybody else.’
 (ii) Possible entailment: ‘They said that they didn’t invite anybody else.’
- b. *To* [PETRA] říkali, že pozvali.
 CDEM Petr.ACC said.3PL C.DECL invited.3PL
 ‘It was Petr that they said they invited.’
 (i) Presupposes: ‘They said that they invited someone.’
 (ii) Does not presuppose: ‘They invited someone.’

The analysis predicts that there will never be more than one CDEM per clause. This is because there is only a single CDEM representing all the different CDEM uses. If a topic-related CDEM is used, for instance, it spells out the whole sequence Top-Foc-Fin-Dem, leaving nothing for a potential focus-related CDEM to spell out. The data that I have been able to observe so far are fully consistent with this prediction. Also, intuitively, constructed examples like (43) are unacceptable. Example (43a) combines a topic-related and a focus-related CDEM.²² Example (43b) combines a topic-/focus-related CDEM with athetic CDEM.²³

- (43) a. **To* [MARIE]_{CT} *to* [S ŘEDITELEM]_F mluvila.
 CDEM Marie CDEM with director spoke
 Intended: ‘As for Marie, it was the director that she spoke with.’
- b. **To* [MARII]_{F/CT} *to* dávám knížku.
 CDEM Marie.DAT CDEM give.1SG book.ACC
 (i) Intended (CT): ‘As for Marie, [if it’s her birthday, then] I give her a book.’
 (ii) Intended (F): ‘It is Marie who [if it’s her birthday, then] I give a book to [her].’

The last prediction that I would like to discuss follows from nanosyntactic spell-out principles. Assuming that the Top-Foc-Fin(-Dem) hierarchy is universal, we expect to see clausal demonstratives that lexicalize, for instance, the whole sequence (like the Czech clausal demonstrative), only the Fin(-Dem) sequence, only the Foc-Fin(-Dem) sequence, but *not*, e.g., the Top-Fin(-Dem) sequence (to the exclusion of the Foc feature). The latter entry would represent the so-called ABA pattern, which is impossible to derive systematically in the nanosyntactic framework (see De Clercq et al. 2025; 2026, among many others). In other words, we can expect to see – cross-linguistically speaking – clausal demonstratives which combine the focus-related function with the thetic function to the

²² It is fair to point out that the sentence is not completely acceptable even in the absence of any CDEM. This is because Czech does not readily allow for focus (or, more specifically, nuclear accent) to occur clause-medially; see Šimík & Wierzbica (2017); Šimík & Jasinskaja (2022).

²³ In a structure with adjunct (hanging) topics (cf. Sturgeon 2006), a combination of a topic-related CDEM and athetic CDEM appears to be possible; see (i).

- (i) *To* [NA NAROZENINY]_{CT}, *to* dávám Marii [KNÍŽKU]_F.
 CDEM for birthday CDEM give.1SG Marie.ACC book.ACC
 ‘When it comes to birthday, I give Mary a book, then.’

In this case, however, the hanging topic appears to be an explicit proxy for the antecedent proposition for the thetic CDEM. It is therefore likely that the structure is biclausal, whereby the first clause, containing the topic, is elliptical.

exclusion of the topic-related function (Foc-Fin-Dem), but not the topic-related function with thethetic function to the exclusion of the focus-related function (*Top-Fin-Dem). It goes beyond the scope of this paper to perform a broader cross-linguistic investigation of this issue, so my contribution will be rather episodic. A relevant case in point which is in line with the prediction is Russian. Russian has two clausal demonstratives – *éto* (corresponding to the nominal demonstrative ‘this.NOM.SG.N’) and *to* (corresponding to ‘that.NOM.SG.N’). It turns out that the functional space is distributed to these two demonstratives in a way consistent with the prediction: *éto* functions as athetic and focus-related demonstrative (Junghanns 1997; Kimmelman 2009), and *to* as a topic-related demonstrative (McCoy 2001; Burukina & den Dikken 2020; Shipova 2023).²⁴ In my analysis, the former encodes the Foc-Fin-Dem sequence and the latter the Top-Foc-Fin-Dem sequence, where the spell-out of other than the topic-related functions is blocked by the Identity Condition on Matching.²⁵

4 Comparison to other analyses

There are numerous accounts of the clausal demonstrative in Slavic languages, esp. Russian and Polish; see Gundel (1988); King (1995); Junghanns (1997); Geist & Błaszczak (2000); McCoy (2001); Ceglowski & Tajsner (2006); Markman (2008); Kimmelman (2009); Reeve (2012); Tajsner (2018); Burukina & den Dikken (2020); Shipova (2023); Milosavljević & Milosavljević (ahead of print). A detailed comparison with each individual analysis is beyond the scope of this paper. However, I would like to point out some general differences and similarities.

There are three common points of departure when approaching the analysis of the Slavic clausal (*éto*): (i) its status as an information structure-sensitive particle (considered in all analyses), (ii) its status as a demonstrative with a deictic, anaphoric, familiarity, or topical function (e.g., Junghanns 1997; Kimmelman 2009; Shipova 2023), and (iii) specificational copular clauses / pseudoclefts (Geist & Błaszczak 2000; Markman 2008; Tajsner 2018; Burukina & den Dikken 2020). My analysis relies crucially on the first two areas, but not on the third one. The idea that CDEM structures are essentially copular clauses or specificational pseudoclefts receives support from data like (44) and (45) (where *éto* is glossed as DEM to avoid analytical bias).

(44) Specificational copular clause (examples from Geist & Błaszczak 2000: 133)

- a. *Polish*
 Jan *to* jest mój przyjaciel.
 Jan DEM is my friend
 ‘Jan is my friend.’
- b. *Russian*
 Ivan *éto* moj drug.
 Ivan DEM my friend
 ‘Ivan is my friend.’

²⁴ Shipova (2023) observes that in colloquial registers, *to* can be used in all three functions, which is, of course, also in line with the prediction.

²⁵ There are interesting and relevant questions which I have to leave unaddressed in this paper for reasons of space. Why does thethetic/focus-related demonstrative take the form of a proximal demonstrative (*éto*), and the topic-related one the form of a distal demonstrative (*to*) (for some discussion of this issue see Burukina & den Dikken 2020)? Why does focus follow the demonstrative (as in Czech), while topic precedes it (as a Spec-Head-based analysis, like the one of Rizzi’s 1997, would predict)? (I add that the same positional contrast is attested in Polish; see Tajsner 2018.) Why does the Closeness Principle (see (27)) in Czech, but not in Russian (Junghanns 1997)?

(45) Specificational pseudocleft (examples cited from Geist & Błaszczak 2000: 134)

- a. *Polish*
 Kogo nie cierpię, *(to) Jacka Kowalskiego.
 who.GEN NEG stand.1SG DEM Jacek Kowalski.GEN
 ‘Who I can’t stand is Jacek Kowalski.’
- b. *Russian*
 Kto menja bespokoit, *(eto) Natali.
 who.NOM me.ACC annoys DEM Natali
 ‘Who annoys me is Natali.’

The analogy between the above uses of *(è)to* and the focus-related CDEM structures is indeed striking: what follows the demonstrative is either a focus (in (45)) or a predicate (in (44)), which corresponds to focus in predication-based approaches to information structure (É. Kiss 2006; Wedgwood 2006; Tajsner 2018).²⁶ However, Czech poses a problem for this neat parallelism because it does not readily use the demonstrative *to* in these constructions and obligatorily uses a standard verbal copula instead:²⁷

- (46) a. Natálie (? to) *(je) moje přítelkyně.
 Natálie DEM is my friend.
 ‘Natálie is my friend.’
- b. Kdo mě štve (? to) *(je) Jan.
 who.NOM me.ACC annoys DEM is Jan.
 ‘Who annoys me is Jan.’

Even though the pseudocleft-based analysis is not as easily motivated for Czech as it is for Polish or Russian, it is important to realize that my analysis achieves a very similar effect, just without reference to a complex syntactic/semantic structure. Just like a standard demonstrative presupposes a contextually salient individual, the clausal demonstrative presupposes a contextually salient proposition and in the case of focus-related demonstratives implies the existence of a set of alternatives, which in turn is a plausible analysis of the pseudocleft *wh*-clause. In other words, what the pseudocleft-based analysis does in *syntax* (and for which the evidence is missing in Czech) is achieved in *semantics* in my analysis, relying on a process independently needed for nominal demonstratives.

My analysis can thus be considered a further development and generalization of analyses which capitalize on the deictic, discourse-anaphoric, or familiarity potential of the clausal demonstrative (Junghanns 1997; Kimmelman 2009; Shipova 2023). For instance, Kimmelman (2009) recognizes both the discourse-anaphoric potential of *eto*, see (47a), as well as the deictic one, see (47b). Both cases fall under what I call the *thetic clausal demonstrative* (a terminology that I adapted from Kimmelman 2009).

(47) *Russian* (adapted from Kimmelman 2009: 326)

²⁶ To bring these structures one step closer to the target CDEM structures, one can assume that what follows *(è)to* is in fact a clause/proposition involving ellipsis; the underlying structure of (45b), for instance, would then be ‘who annoys me is (=) Natali annoys me’. See esp. Burukina & den Dikken (2020) for the latest development of this type of analysis, applied not only to the focus-related, but also the topic-related CDEM.

²⁷ For completeness, I point out that *to* is perfectly acceptable in the absence of a nominal subject, as in *To je moje přítelkyně* ‘It is my friend.’ Relatedly, the presence of *to* in (46) is unproblematic if it is preceded by a prosodic break.

- a. V sosednej komnate razdalsja šum. *Ěto* Petja razbil okno.
in next room there.was noise CDEM Petja broke window
‘There was a noise in the next room. (It was because) Petja broke the window.’
- b. *Situation:* Petja and Vasja are walking in the field. Then there is a noise. Vasja is surprised, but Petja says:
Ěto sobaki lajut.
CDEM dogs bark
‘Dogs are barking.’

My proposal follows the same basic intuition, but, in addition, it relates it to independently motivated analyses of nominal demonstratives and applies the analysis to all three attested types of clausal demonstratives.

5 Summary and open issues

I have proposed a novel analysis of the Czech clausal demonstrative which crucially relies on the idea that the clausal demonstrative is in principle just an ordinary demonstrative enriched by the capacity to apply to propositions (due to the Fin head), to propositional focus semantic values (due to the Foc head), and to topic semantic values (due to the Top head). Syntactically, the analysis is based on the cartographic approach to the left periphery (Rizzi 1997), particularly the Top-Foc-Fin sequence, and the nanosyntactic approach to spell-out and morphology (Starke 2009; De Clercq et al. 2025), which makes it possible to treat all different uses of the clausal demonstrative as subsets of the same lexically encoded structure. Semantically, I have implemented the widely accepted idea that the core function of a demonstrative is to relate (usually, but not necessarily by the identity relation) the denotation of its complement to a contextually salient referent of the same semantic type. I have proposed an incremental way of deriving the topic-related demonstrative (TOP) from the focus-related demonstrative (FOC), the focus-related demonstrative from thethetic demonstrative (FIN), and thethetic demonstrative from the core demonstrative meaning (DEM).

Despite the principled approach and relatively solid empirical coverage, many issues remain to be addressed. What I have left aside in this paper is the clausal demonstrative used in *wh*-questions (Šimík 2009; Yermalanov & Philippova 2023), which appears to share some features with the focus-related demonstrative (activation of alternatives), but others with thethetic demonstrative (potentially reference to sub-propositional entities such as events; see footnote 20). This type of demonstrative was only briefly discussed at the end of section 2.1. Another issue worth more attention is the relation between Czech (or Slavic) focus-related clausal demonstratives and standard English-style biclausal clefts (which are, by the way, also attested in Czech). While the understanding of the syntax, truth conditions, presuppositions, and use conditions of English *it*-clefts has progressed significantly in the past years (Velleman et al. 2012; Buring & Križ 2013; De Veugh-Geiss et al. 2018; Amiraz 2024; among others), Czech (or Slavic) focus-related demonstratives are still relatively poorly understood (though cf. Kimmelman 2009). Last but not least, clausal demonstratives are a subtype of the broader class of clausal determiners. A preliminary comparison (see section 3.2.4) suggests that – just like in the nominal domain – we can distinguish between clausal *demonstratives* and clausal *articles*, whereby the contribution of the former is mainly discourse-anaphoric, while the contribution of the latter concerns the truth-conditional level (such as factivity; cf. Wespel 2008 on Haitian

Creole). It would be interesting to see whether this distinction correlates with the grammatical toolkit attested in the nominal domain in a given language (the (un)availability of articles/demonstratives).

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